A galvanometer is converted into a voltmeter by connecting high resistance R_h in series with galvanometer as shown in Figure 3.74. The scale is now calibrated in volt and the range of voltmeter depends on the values of the resistance connected in series i.e. the value of resistance is so adjusted that only current I_g produces full scale deflection in the galvanometer.

Let R_g be the resistance of galvanometer and I_g be the current with which the galvanometer produces full scale deflection. Since the galvanometer is connected in series with high resistance, the current in the electrical circuit is same as the current passing through the galvanometer.

$$I = I_g$$

$$I = I_g \Rightarrow I_g = \frac{\text{potential difference}}{\text{total resistance}}$$

Since the galvanometer and high resistance are connected in series, the total resistance or effective resistance gives the resistance of voltmeter. The voltmeter resistance is

$$R_v = R_g + R_h$$

Therefore,

$$I_g = \frac{V}{R_g + R_h}$$

$$\Rightarrow R_h = \frac{V}{I_g} - R_g$$

Note that $I_g \propto V$

The deflection in the galvanometer is proportional to current I_g. But current I_g is proportional to the potential difference. Hence the deflection in the galvanometer is proportional to potential difference. Since the resistance of voltmeter is very large, a voltmeter connected in an electrical circuit will draw least current in the circuit. An ideal voltmeter is one which has infinite resistance.

Key points

1. Voltmeter is a high resistance instrument and it is always connected in parallel with the circuit element across which the potential difference is to be calculated
2. An ideal voltmeter has infinite resistance
3. In order to increase the range of voltmeter n times the value of resistance to be connected in series with galvanometer is R = (n-1) G

UNIT-3(XII-Physics_Vol-1).indd 195 04-03-2019 10:35:56